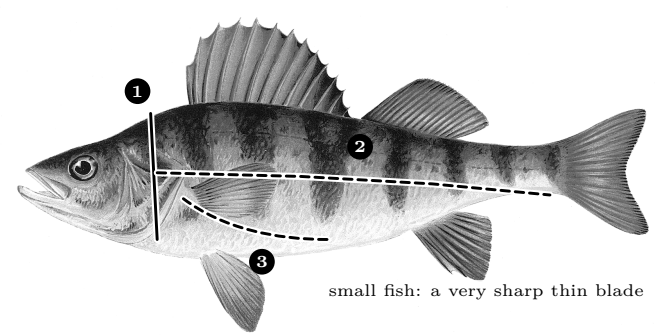




Yellow or Barred Perch — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The best-eating fish in either lake, and arguably in fresh water. Sweeter and firmer than walleye, in a smaller package.
Texture	Firm, fine-grained, faintly sweet. Never mushy.
Best size	9 in and up makes filleting worth the effort. Below that, pan-dress instead.
Yield	Low — about 25%, and a 9 in perch gives two fillets of barely 1.5 oz. This is a fish you need a dozen of.
Ice fishing	Winter perch out of 34 °F water are the best of all. see the <i>Seasonal Calendar sheet</i>
Scales	Fine and very well attached. Filleting and skinning beats scaling every time.

Filleting a small fish

1. Use a **thin, very sharp, flexible blade**. A thick knife on a 9 in perch wastes half the fish.
2. **Cut behind the gill plate** down to the backbone.
3. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail in one stroke. On a fish this small, resist sawing.
4. **Skin it** from the tail, and take the ribs with the skin if you can — on perch it is often faster to cut the rib section away entirely and accept the small loss.
5. **Or pan-dress instead:** scale, gut, cut the head off behind the gills, and cook it whole on the bone. Below about 9 in this gives you more food than filleting does.

Bones and what to watch for

Spiny dorsal	The first dorsal fin is genuinely sharp and so are the gill covers. Handle a live perch from the head-on direction, or with a cloth.
Rib cage	Small and fine. Cut it out or pull it with pliers.
Nothing else	No Y-bones, no pin bones. A perch fillet is clean.
Pan-dressed	Eaten off the bone, the frame lifts out in one piece after cooking.

Cooking it

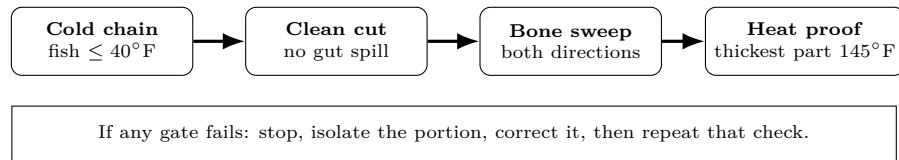
Method	How
Pan-fried	The only method that really matters. Egg wash, then cracker crumbs or fine cornmeal. Butter, medium-high, ninety seconds a side. They are small — they cook fast.
Perch fry	The Friday institution. Beer batter, 375 °F, two to three minutes. Serve with rye bread, coleslaw and a lemon wedge, which is how it is done here.
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed fish, scored, dusted in seasoned flour, shallow-fried until the fins go crisp. Eat the fins. They are the best part and nobody believes it until they try.

Worth the work

Perch are small and cleaning a dozen takes a while, which is exactly why so few people bother and why the ones who do eat better than everybody else. Set up an assembly line: one person fillets, one skins, one rinses and ices. Twenty

minutes for a family meal of the best fish in the county.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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